Abraham: The Call and the Covenant

Genesis 12; 15; 22

The big idea: God chose to rescue the world through one man. He called Abram, promised him a land, a people, and a blessing for every nation, swore by himself to keep it, and counted Abram righteous because he believed. On Moriah God provided a substitute, pointing to the Son he would not spare.

Before you meet: Read

Genesis 12:1–9 | Genesis 15:1–21 | Genesis 22:1–19 | Romans 4:18–25

Open (5 minutes)

Have you ever waited a long time for something you were promised? What did the waiting do to you?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"Go from your country and your kindred and your father's house to the _____ that I will show you." *(Genesis 12:1)*

"And in you all the _____ of the earth shall be blessed." *(Genesis 12:3)*

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as _____." *(Genesis 15:6)*

"A smoking fire pot and a flaming _____ passed between these _____." *(Genesis 15:17)*

"God will _____ for himself the lamb for a burnt offering, my son." *(Genesis 22:8)*

"And Abraham went and took the ram and offered it up as a burnt offering _____ of his son." *(Genesis 22:13)*

Discuss

1. Abram's family "served other gods." What does it tell you about grace that God called Abram before Abram was looking for him? *Joshua 24:2; Genesis 12:1–4*

2. Soon after arriving, Abram lied about Sarai in Egypt. Why do you think Genesis tells us about his failures? How does that encourage you? *Genesis 12:10–13*

3. In the covenant ceremony, Abram was asleep and only God passed between the pieces. What does that say about who keeps God's promises? *Genesis 15:12–18*

4. "He counted it to him as righteousness." In your own words, what does it mean to be justified by faith? *Genesis 15:6; Romans 4:4–5*

5. Sarai and Abram tried to get the promised son by their own plan, through Hagar. Where are you tempted to make God's promises happen your own way instead of waiting on him? *Genesis 16:1–4*

6. Isaac carried the wood up the mountain, and a ram died in his place. Jesus carried his cross, and no one took his place. If God did not spare his own Son, where do you need to trust him to "graciously give us all things" this week? *Genesis 22:6–13; Romans 8:32*

Apply this week

Go outside one night this week and look at the stars, as Abram did. Read Genesis 15 and 22 again and mark every promise God makes. Then name one gift you are tempted to love more than God himself, and give it back to him in prayer, trusting that he provides.

Memory verse

"And he believed the LORD, and he counted it to him as righteousness."

Genesis 15:6

Pray

Thank God that he counts righteousness to everyone who trusts his promise, just as he did for Abraham. Thank him for providing the Lamb, his own Son, in our place. Ask him for faith to rest your whole weight on Jesus.

LEADER NOTES · LESSON 6

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Session plan (about 70 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Genesis 12:1–9 and 15:1–6 aloud together. Then read 22:1–14.
10 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
30 min	Discuss: choose 4 of the 6 questions. Questions 3, 4, and 6 matter most.
5 min	Name the three scenes (the call, the covenant, the mountain) and walk the group through the Moriah and Calvary diagram in the full lesson.
10 min	Apply and pray. Introduce the memory verse and the reading for Lesson 7 (Genesis 25:19–34; 28:10–22; 32:22–32; 37; 45).

Main points to land

1. God rescues the world through one man and one family. He called Abram, the son of an idol-worshiping family, before Abram was seeking him (Josh. 24:2; Gen. 12:1).
2. God made three promises that run through the whole Bible: a land, a people, and a blessing for all the families of the earth. Paul calls Genesis 12:3 the gospel preached beforehand (Gal. 3:8).
3. Abram was justified by faith alone. He believed, and God counted it to him as righteousness (Gen. 15:6; Rom. 4:5). Faith receives that righteousness; it does not supply it (WCF 11.1).
4. Only God passed between the pieces. The covenant rests on God's faithfulness, and Abram's lies and the Hagar plan could not undo it (Gen. 15:17; Heb. 6:13).
5. On Moriah God provided a ram instead of Isaac. On Calvary God did not spare his own Son, the Lamb of God who takes away the sin of the world (Gen. 22:13; Rom. 8:32; John 1:29).

Answer key (Observe)

1. land
2. families
3. righteousness
4. torch; pieces
5. provide
6. instead

Questions people will ask

How could God tell Abraham to sacrifice his own son?
Let the group feel the weight of it. Genesis says from the first line that this was a test (22:1), and God stopped it. Later he forbade child sacrifice as something "which I did not command, nor did it come into my mind" (Jer. 7:31). Abraham expected to come back with Isaac, because God was able to raise him from the dead (Gen. 22:5; Heb. 11:19). The scene points ahead to the Father who did not spare his own Son.

James says Abraham was "justified by works." Doesn't that contradict Genesis 15:6?
James quotes Genesis 15:6 himself (James 2:23). Paul asks how a sinner is declared righteous before God: by faith alone. James asks how you can tell faith is real: by what it does. Abraham was counted righteous decades before Moriah, and Moriah showed his faith was genuine. Faith alone justifies, but justifying faith is never alone (WCF 11.2).

Why did God pick Abram? Was he better than everyone else?
No. His family worshiped idols, and he lied about his wife soon after he obeyed. God chose him by grace, and he chose one man so that the blessing would reach every nation through him (Gen. 12:3). Lesson 7 says more about God's choosing. Keep the group on the main point: God starts the rescue.

Jews, Christians, and Muslims all call Abraham their father. Are they all his children?
Many people claim Abraham by birth or tradition. The New Testament says "it is those of faith who are the sons of Abraham" (Gal. 3:7), and "if you are Christ's, then you are Abraham's offspring" (Gal. 3:29). Jesus said Abraham rejoiced to see his day (John 8:56). Answer kindly, and point people to the promised Offspring.

Closing prayer

Father, thank you for calling Abraham when he was not looking for you, and for calling us the same way. Thank you that you swore by yourself to keep your promise, and that you count righteous all who believe. Thank you for not sparing your own Son. Give each of us faith to rest our whole weight on Jesus, who died and rose for us. Amen.